

Title: The Proof: Lessons in Leading Public Health Communication of Alcohol-Related Cancer Risk Using a Multimedia Campaign and Knowledge Mobilization Toolkit

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Background: Alcohol contributed to 7,000 cancer cases in Canada in 2020. Studies confirm its role in increasing the risk of certain cancers, including breast, mouth, throat (pharynx and larynx), esophagus, colon, rectum, and liver. Furthermore, approximately one in five Canadian adults increased their alcohol consumption during the COVID-19 pandemic, underscoring the need for resources. In January 2023, Canada's Guidance on Alcohol and Health replaced the Low-Risk Alcohol Drinking Guidelines (2011), introducing a risk continuum expressed in standard drinks per week. In response to the updated guidelines, BC Cancer launched a provincial campaign aimed at empowering individuals to re-contextualize alcohol-related cancer risk and make evidence-informed decisions regarding their health.

Methods: In April 2023, partnering with B.C.'s Ministry of Health and Be The Change Group, a population and public health consulting firm, BC Cancer launched "The Proof", a multimedia public health campaign to increase awareness of the link between alcohol consumption and cancer. The campaign's design focused on three key communication goals: 1) increase awareness of the link between alcohol consumption and cancer, 2) provide tools to help audiences better understand their alcohol intake and corresponding cancer risk and 3) increase awareness of Canada's new low-risk drinking guidelines and data. The target demographic was B.C. residents ages 25-49 who consume alcohol. The campaign consisted of advertising across the province using familiar tactics known to traditional alcohol marketing, social media and content creator engagement, strategic partnerships, and the development of a website featuring knowledge mobilization resources such as a Standard Drink Calculator Quiz. This allowed individuals to personalize their weekly alcohol intake and associated cancer risk. To assess outcomes of the campaign, an evaluation was conducted using data collected from social media and website analytics, online pop-up surveys, and street-intercept surveys.

Results: The campaign observed significant engagement across different media. Over 37,000 new users visited The Proof website, demonstrating strong public interest. The calculator quiz delivered actionable outcomes, revealing that 40% of users were at high-risk, 28% at medium-risk and 23% at low-risk. Furthermore, approximately half of survey participants expressed a likelihood to drink less after seeing the campaign.

Conclusions: The Proof campaign significantly increased knowledge among B.C. residents about the link between alcohol and cancer. The Proof provided evidence-based tools for individuals to make informed decisions about their alcohol use. Future work may also benefit from investment in partnerships with community stakeholders, and leveraging social media and other forms of online advertising. Public health professionals should continue to approach the topic of alcohol consumption and cancer risk in ways that are factual, non-judgmental, and encourage positive behavior change for cancer prevention.

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